



WEEK FIVE · MODULE TWO

The Codes of the Trade

The confidential note on suppliers, money, and the machinery behind the money

THE PRIVATE CONCIERGE ACADEMY

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HOW TO STUDY THIS MODULE

This is the note about the part of the profession that nobody puts in a brochure: the vendors, the commissions, the renovations, and the quiet ways good people are compromised.

Almost nobody is corrupted at this level. A great many people are compromised, slowly, in ways they did not notice, and the difference between those two words is the subject of this note.

Read it before you build your black book, not after.

CHAPTER I

How this world really treats you

You are the door, and everybody knows it

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Understand your position in the eyes of the supply side.

Recognise the flattery for what it is.

From the moment you take a role in a wealthy household, your professional life changes in a way that nobody warns you about: **you become interesting to a great many people who have never met you.**

Galleries. Interior designers. Charter brokers. Jewellers. Property agents. Wine merchants. Private banks. Concierge companies. Watch dealers. Every one of them wants access to your principal, and you are standing in the doorway.

And so you will be treated extremely well. You will be invited to previews. You will be offered upgrades, and dinners, and a car when you need one, and a table at a restaurant that told the public it was full. It is genuinely pleasant, and it is genuinely intoxicating, and here is the sentence you must hold on to:

THE THING TO REMEMBER, PERMANENTLY

None of it is for you. All of it is for the door you are standing in.

That is not cynicism and it is not bitterness. It is simply an accurate description of a commercial relationship, and the professionals who understand it are calm and pleasant and never confused. The ones who believe the flattery is personal are the ones who are eventually compromised, and they never see it coming, because it did not feel like a bribe. It felt like a friendship.

There is one perfectly clean version of this: a supplier treats you well because you are professional, you pay on time, you brief them properly and you do not waste their day. That is a real relationship, and it is the one you want, and it is recognisable by a simple test. **Would they still take your call if you left the household tomorrow?** If yes, it is real. If not, it never was.

CHAPTER II

The commission economy

The machinery that will be explained to you as normal

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Recognise every form the offer takes.

Know exactly what you say, and what you then do.

Nobody will ever offer you a bribe. That is not how it works, and if it were that crude, nobody would fall for it.

What happens is this. Somebody explains an arrangement to you, kindly and casually, as though it were an ordinary feature of the industry. And in their industry, sometimes it genuinely is.

What you will be told

What it actually is

"There is a referral fee, it is completely standard in our sector."

A payment to you for choosing them. It is standard in some sectors, and it is still a payment to you, from someone your employer is about to pay, to influence a decision you are making with your employer's money.

"We would take care of you, obviously."

The same thing, unquantified, so that you cannot refuse a number that was never named.

"Let us put your commission in the quote, the client never sees it."

This one at least is honest. It tells you exactly who is paying: the family, without knowing.

"Come and stay for a weekend, on us, so that you know the property."

Sometimes entirely legitimate, and it is called a site inspection, and it is normal in travel. The test is whether your house knows about it. If you would not mention it to the principal, it is not an inspection.

"A small thank you." A watch. A handbag. A case of wine.

A gift above a trivial value, from a supplier, to the person who selects suppliers. Whatever it is called, that is what it is.

2.1 · What you say

Warmly, without a lecture, without any suggestion that they have insulted you, because very often they have not and they genuinely do not understand:

THE WORDS

"That is kind, but I do not take commissions. I am paid by the family and that is the only side I am on. It would not be right and it would not be worth it to me."

Then continue the conversation about the work as though nothing happened, because nothing did.

2.2 · What you then do, which is the half that people skip

You tell the household that it was offered. In one line, without drama, at the next natural moment. "The broker offered a referral fee, I declined it."

People find this step unnecessary and it is the most important step there is. You did nothing wrong, so there is nothing to hide, and saying so out loud converts a private virtue into a documented one. And on the day someone else in the house is offered the same fee and takes it, you are the person who already said so.

2.3 · The gift policy you will need

- **Trivial and consumable is fine.** A bottle at Christmas, chocolates, flowers. Nobody has ever been compromised by a panettone.
- **Anything of real value goes to the house.** Declared, logged, and it belongs to the household, not to you, and if the household tells you to keep it then you keep it with a clear conscience and a written record.
- **Anything from a supplier you are currently selecting is declined, always.** Even a small thing. Especially a small thing, because the small thing is the one that establishes the pattern.

CHAPTER III

What a supplier is actually selling you

And it is not the service

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Read a quote correctly.

Understand what you are paying for at this level.

3.1 · The uncomfortable arithmetic

At this level you will very often pay two or three times what something is objectively worth, and it will be the correct decision. This confuses people badly in their first year, and it makes them feel foolish, and some of them try to be clever about it and cost themselves the position.

You are not buying the flowers. You are buying: **certainty, availability, discretion, and a person who answers the telephone at eleven at night.** Those four things are the product. The flowers are the packaging.

3.2 · Where the money actually goes

You appear to be paying for

You are actually paying for

The car	A driver who has been vetted, who has signed something, who will not tell anyone who was in the car, and who is there at 06:40 rather than 06:52.
The table	The certainty of the table. On the night. At the hour. Without a photograph. That certainty has a price and it is not the food.
The charter	Not the aircraft. The absence of a terminal, a queue, a photograph, and a schedule that belongs to somebody else.
The contractor	That they will not photograph the house, will not discuss the house, and will be gone by the day they said.

3.3 · The one place you must be ruthless

None of the above is a reason to be a soft buyer. **The suppliers know exactly how they are treated by wealthy households, and a great many of them price accordingly.**

So: always two quotes, always, even when you are certain. Ask what the price would be without the elements you did not ask for. Ask what the repositioning costs. Ask what happens if it is cancelled. Every one of those questions is normal, professional, and unembarrassing, and asking them will earn you more respect from a serious supplier than accepting the first number ever will.

And know the difference between the two mistakes. Being expensive is a mistake you can explain in one sentence. **Being taken for a fool is a mistake that makes the house wonder what else you are not watching.**

CHAPTER IV

The friend of the house

The position you are quietly working towards

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Understand what a supplier relationship becomes when it is done properly.

There is a thing that happens, after about three years in this profession, that nobody explains to you in advance and that is the real reward of the work.

Suppliers begin to answer your calls first.

Not because you pay them the most. Because **you are the client who briefs properly, pays on time, never blames them in front of the family, never asks them to lie, and never makes their evening worse than it needed to be.** There are very few of those, and every good supplier in a city can name them.

WHAT THIS IS WORTH

The table on the night everything is full. The florist who opens on a Sunday. The broker who finds an aircraft in four hours. The contractor who moves you to the front.

That is the black book, and it is not a list. It is a reputation, and it takes years, and it belongs to you rather than to any house, and it is a large part of why the twelfth year of this career is paid so much better than the second.

And it is built almost entirely out of small, unglamorous decencies. You gave them the brief in writing. You told them the truth about the budget. You paid the invoice in eleven days rather than sixty. You called to say it went well. **You never once made them the villain in a story you told the principal.**

CHAPTER V

The renovation

The single most dangerous project in this profession

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Understand why renovations destroy careers.

Know the four rules before you are inside one.

If you are given a renovation, understand what has actually happened: you have been handed the project with the highest failure rate in private service, and you have been handed it because someone senior did not want it.

Renovations end careers, routinely, and for reasons that have almost nothing to do with taste.

Why it kills people	What it looks like
It always overruns	Every project, everywhere, in every century. The failure is not the overrun. The failure is that the principal learned about it late, from someone else.
The scope grows invisibly	A hundred small "while we are here" decisions, each individually reasonable, and none of them written down, and the total is forty per cent over budget and nobody can say when it happened.
The money is enormous and the oversight is thin	You will be signing off amounts that would have been a scandal in your previous life, and the person checking is you.
The house is open for months	Contractors, deliveries, unfamiliar people, doors propped open, photographs taken. Every Week 3 rule you learned is under pressure every single day.

5.1 · The four rules

- Everything in writing, including the small things, especially the small things. Every variation, dated, priced, and approved by the person who is entitled to approve it. Verbal approval of a variation does not exist. It was never given, whatever anyone remembers.
- The weekly report, whether or not anyone asks for it. One page. Where we are, what has changed, what it costs, what I need. Every week, on the same day, for the entire project.

This one habit is worth the whole module.

- **Bad news travels at full speed.** The moment you know the date will slip, they know. Not when you have a solution. Not when it is confirmed. When you know.
- **You are not the designer.** You do not have opinions about their taste, you do not steer choices towards what you would have chosen, and you never, ever say "I would have gone with the other one" to anyone at all.

CHAPTER VI

Case law

*Six operational stories***LEARNING OBJECTIVES**

Recognise these before you are inside one.

The eleven euros

A house in Geneva. Petty cash. A house manager of four years, entirely honest, universally liked.

At the audit, the cash was eleven euros short. Not eleven thousand. Eleven. She could not say why, and she was not lying, and there was nothing to find.

She was gone within two months. **Nobody thought she was a thief.** They thought she was not in control, and in a household, those two things produce exactly the same outcome, and this is the single most misunderstood fact in this profession.

The referral fee

A charter broker, over eight years, paid an estate manager a quiet five per cent on every flight he booked. He booked a great many. It was, in the broker's industry, entirely normal, and it was never hidden from the broker's side.

It surfaced in a routine cost review, from the broker's own accounts, in a sentence in an email.

He argued, and he was not entirely wrong, that he had always chosen good aircraft, that the family had never suffered, that the prices were competitive. It made no difference at all. **The moment the family understood that his selection had a second beneficiary, everything he had ever recommended was reopened.** Eight years of work, all of it fine, all of it now suspect. He left the profession.

The quote he did not take twice

A young house manager, capable and eager, booked a charter from the first broker he called, at forty-one thousand for a routing that a second quote, obtained twenty minutes

later by a colleague, priced at twenty-six.

Nobody was defrauded. The first price was a real price, honestly quoted, in an opaque market.

The principal never mentioned it. The family office did, once, to the principal. **He was not fired for the fifteen thousand. He was reclassified in a single conversation, from someone who runs things to someone who needs checking,** and he never recovered the position.

The Sunday florist

A different estate manager, in the same city, over six years, did nothing remarkable at all. She briefed her suppliers in writing. She paid their invoices in ten days when everyone else in the city paid in ninety. She never once blamed one of them in front of a principal, including on the occasions when it was entirely their fault.

On the Saturday evening before an important lunch, an entire delivery was ruined in transit.

Her florist opened his shop on the Sunday morning, alone, and rebuilt the whole thing in four hours, and would not invoice for the extra. **That is what the black book actually is,** and it cannot be bought, and it cannot be taken from her.

The renovation that was fine

A country property, an eighteen-month project, forty per cent over the original budget, and four months late.

And the house manager who ran it was promoted at the end of it.

Because every single week, for seventy-eight weeks, a one-page report arrived on the same day. Every variation was written, priced, and approved before the work was done. And on the day she knew the date would slip, which was five weeks before it slipped, she said so, in four sentences, with two options. **The principal never learned a single thing about that project from anybody except her.** That is the whole of it.

The handbag

An interior designer, at the end of a large and profitable project, sent the house manager a handbag. Retail, a little over four thousand euros. A thank you, and quite sincerely meant, and in her industry, unremarkable.

The house manager kept it. She did not hide it, exactly. She simply did not mention it, because mentioning it felt awkward, and it was a gift, and the project was finished.

Eleven months later the same designer was proposed for the second property, and the family office asked, routinely, whether there was any reason to prefer them. And a colleague, without malice, mentioned the bag.

Nothing was ever said to her. She was not accused of anything, because there was nothing to accuse her of. She simply stopped being asked for her opinion on suppliers, and then, eventually, on anything.

Glossary

The door · What suppliers actually want from you. Access to your principal. It is never personal, and understanding that keeps you calm.

The referral fee · A payment to you for selecting a supplier. Standard in some industries, fatal in this one. Declined and disclosed.

The site inspection · A legitimate visit to a property you are considering. The test: does your house know about it?

The gift line · Trivial and consumable, you may keep. Anything of value goes to the house, declared and logged.

The second quote · Always. Even when you are certain. Especially when you are certain.

Friend of the house · The supplier relationship built over years on decency, correct briefing, and prompt payment. The real black book.

The variation · Any change to an agreed scope. Written, priced, approved, before the work. A verbal variation does not exist.

The weekly report · One page, same day, every week, whether or not anyone asked for it. The habit that saves renovations.

Self-assessment

Answer in writing.

1. A supplier treats you extremely well. Give the one question that tells you whether the relationship is real.
2. Write, word for word, what you say when a referral fee is offered. Then write what you do in the ten minutes afterwards.
3. Why is disclosing the offer as important as declining it? Answer in terms of what happens eleven months later.
4. A supplier sends you a handbag after a completed project. Walk through your exact actions, in order.
5. Explain why paying three times the objective price can be the correct decision, and what you are actually buying.
6. Explain the difference between being an expensive buyer and being a foolish one, and why only one of them is survivable.
7. In the case of the eleven euros: nobody believed she was a thief. Why was she gone in two months?
8. You are handed an eighteen-month renovation. Write the four rules you will operate under, before you take a single decision.
9. Why is a verbal approval of a variation worth nothing, even when the person who gave it is entirely honest?
10. Of the six cases, which failure is closest to one you could make? Do not choose a flattering answer.

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